# Safe Use of Devices

## Introduction

A comprehensive research on safe use of devices, the research identifies various means of safe use of devices and these are followed:

## Electronic devices:

This includes smartphones, tablets, laptops, desktop computers, televisions, headphones, gaming consoles, smart-home devices, and rechargeable battery products are now part of everyday life. They provide major benefits for communication, education, work and entertainment, but unsafe use can create electrical, fire, physical, ergonomic, hearing, privacy and cybersecurity risks. Safe device use therefore means more than simply avoiding physical damage which involves the following categories:

## (a) Precaution through the following steps:

- Using electrical equipment and chargers correctly.
- Preventing overheating and battery fires.
- Keeping software and security protections up to date.
- Protecting passwords, personal information and privacy.
- Using screens and workstations ergonomically.
- Protecting hearing when using headphones.
- Supervising children's use appropriately.
- Recognising damaged or malfunctioning equipment.
- Disposing of batteries and electronic equipment responsibly. The guidance below draws particularly on the UK Health and Safety Executive (HSE), National Cyber Security Centre (NCSC), GOV.UK, Electrical Safety First and World Health Organization (WHO)

## (b) Major risks associated with device use:

### The risk and the examples of possible consequences are:

Electrical damaged cables, overloaded sockets, faulty chargers, electric shock, burns fire Battery Damaged or overheating lithium-ion batteries rapid fire, smoke burn burns ergonomic poor posture, unsuitable workstation Neck, shoulder, back and wrist discomfort. Visual Long periods of screen work eye fatigue, headaches discomfort

Hearing High-volume headphones/gaming, hearing damage, tinnitus, Cybersecurity outdated software, weak passwords, phishing, Account takeover, malware, data theft privacy, Excessive permissions, unsecured smart devices, unwanted access or data collection, physical accidents, cables across walkways, devices falling, trips, falls, injuries, child safety, unrestricted online access or unsuitable content, privacy, exploitation, cyberbullying and other online risks, fire, charging on beds/soft furnishings or overheating and potentially fire.

## (c) Electrical safety

Electrical equipment should be inspected regularly, damaged plugs, cables, sockets or chargers should not be ignored.

### Warning signs include:

- Burn marks.
- Buzzing or crackling.
- Sparks or arcing.
- A plug or socket becoming unusually hot.
- Repeatedly blown fuses or tripped circuit breakers.
- Frayed, crushed or exposed cables.
- Unusual smells.

Electrical Safety First advises disconnecting suspect equipment and contacting the retailer, manufacturer or a suitably qualified repair professional rather than continuing to use it. Electrical Safety First+1

Extension leads and sockets Overloading sockets or extension leads can cause overheating and fire. Extension leads should not be connected to other extension leads

("daisy chaining"), and the total load should remain within the equipment's rated capacity. Electrical Safety First+1

A safer approach is to:

1. Use wall sockets wherever practical.
2. Check the rating of an extension lead before use.
3. Avoid daisy chaining.
4. Keep cables away from heat and water.
5. Replace damaged cables rather than attempting unsafe repairs.
6. Keep cables arranged so they do not create trip hazards.

An RCD (residual current device) can provide additional protection against electric shock where electrical equipment develops a fault. Electrical Safety First+1

## (d) Safe use of chargers and batteries:

Modern portable electronics commonly use lithium-ion batteries. These batteries are generally safe when correctly designed, maintained and used, but **damage, overheating, poor-quality components or improper charging can create serious fire risks**. GOV.UK specifically warns about the potential risks associated with damaged or improperly used lithium batteries. GOV.UK+1

### Good charging practices:

- Use the manufacturer's charger or a reputable, compatible replacement.
- Charge on a **hard, flat, non-flammable surface**.
- Do not charge underneath pillows, blankets or other materials that retain heat.
- Keep chargers and batteries away from water.
- Avoid extreme temperatures.
- Do not use visibly damaged batteries.
- Do not continue charging a battery that becomes abnormally hot.
- Avoid charging while asleep or away from home where possible, particularly for larger lithium battery products.

- Disconnect the charger when charging is complete, following the manufacturer's instructions.
- Keep charging equipment away from escape routes.
- Do not use counterfeit or suspiciously cheap chargers.

These precautions are particularly important for e-bikes, e-scooters and other products containing larger lithium battery packs. GOV.UK+1

## Warning signs of battery failure

### A battery should be treated as potentially hazardous if it:

- Becomes extremely hot.
- Swells or bulges.
- Develops a leak.
- Produces an unusual smell.
- Makes hissing or cracking noises.
- Takes substantially longer than normal to charge.
- Produces smoke.

# (e) Safe use of computers, laptops and tablets:

## Ergonomics:

Prolonged computer use can contribute to discomfort involving the neck, shoulders, back, arms, wrists and hands, particularly when the workstation or posture is poor. HSE guidance recommends assessing the workstation and reducing identified risks. HSE+1

### A suitable workstation should generally have:

- The top of the screen approximately at eye level.
- The screen roughly an arm's length away.
- The screen directly in front of the user.
- Shoulders relaxed.
- Keyboard around elbow height.

- A chair providing adequate lower-back support.
- The mouse positioned comfortably in line with the elbow.
- Adequate lighting with minimal glare.

For prolonged laptop use, HSE recommends considering a separate keyboard and mouse so that the laptop screen can be raised without forcing the user's arms and wrists into an uncomfortable position. HSE

## Breaks:

Long uninterrupted periods at a screen should be avoided. HSE recommends short, frequent breaks or changes of activity, rather than relying on occasional long breaks. As an example, HSE states that 5–10 minutes every hour can be preferable to 20 minutes every two hours, although the appropriate arrangement depends on the work being performed. HSE+1

### When apply breaks, users should:

- Stand up.
- Walk around.
- Stretch.
- Change posture.
- Look away from the screen.

## 2. Multi-factor (MFA) and Two-factor (2FA) Authentication.

## ‘Something you know’

(PSharma,CyberSecurity, 2025.) The ‘something you know’ factor refers to an authentication process which relies on information a user can remember, for example, a password, passphrase or a personal identification number (PIN). In multi-factor authentication (MFA), this factor can be combined with other forms of verification, such as something a unique physical characteristic or something a person possesses, to provide an additional layer of security. Two-factor authentication (2FA) is a type of MFA which requires two different authentication factors to verify a user’s identity.

## ‘Something you have’

(National Cyber Security Centre, 2026). The something you have authentication factor refers to a physical or digital credential that a user possesses to verify their identity. In FIDO2 authentication, this factor is represented by a private, cryptographic key stored within an authenticator, such as a mobile device or a physical security key. When combined with user verification through a PIN, biometric feature or a password, this provides multiple layers of authentication and helps protect accounts from unauthorised access.

## ‘Something you are’

(National Cyber Security Centre, 2026) The ‘something you are’ authentication factor refers to a person’s unique biological characteristics, such as their facial features or fingerprint, which can be used to verify their identity. In multi-factor authentication (MFA), biometric recognition can be combined with another authentication factor, such as a passkey stored on a device. For example, a user may need to verify their identity using facial recognition or a fingerprint before their device allows them to use a passkey to access an online account. This combines something you have (cryptographic credential or the device) with something you are (the user’s biometric information), providing two distinct authentication factors. However, biometric authentication does not eliminate every security risk. Devices can still be compromised, and the security of the authentication process depends on how the device, and its authentication systems are implemented and protected. Therefore, organisations should consider both the benefits and potential vulnerabilities of biometric authentication when choosing suitable security measures.

## Weaknesses of Traditional Multi-Factor Authentication.

(National Cyber Security Centre, n.d.) Traditional MFA methods, such as authenticator applications, SMS verification codes and hardware-generated one-time passwords (OTPs), give an additional layer of security beyond passwords. However, these methods have certain vulnerabilities and do not offer the same level of protection against modern cyberattacks. A key weakness is that traditional MFA methods remain susceptible to phishing, particularly adversary-in-the-middle (AiTM) attacks, where attackers use fraudulent websites to relay authentication information to legitimate services in real time

(National Cyber Security Centre, n.d) SMS-based authentication is vulnerable to SIM-swapping attacks, where criminals transfer and victims telephone number to a SIM card under their control, allowing them to receive verification codes intended for the legitimate user. SMS codes may also be intercepted by certain types of malware, particularly on mobile devices. Consequently, although SMS verification can reduce the risks associated with password theft, it does not provide strong protection against attackers who can obtain or relay the additional authentication code.

Hardware OTP tokens provide another authentication option by generating codes using a physical device. They can reduce certain risks associated with software-based credential storage and malware, particularly when the token is separate from the user's computer. However, hardware-generated OTPs remain vulnerable to phishing and AiTM attacks because the codes are not cryptographically bound to the legitimate website. Attackers can therefore relay a valid code to the genuine service during its short validity period.

Overall, traditional MFA methods improve account security compared with password-only authentication, but they do not eliminate the risk of account compromise. The National Cyber Security Centre’s comparison identifies phishing- resistant FiDO2 credentials, including passkeys and security keys, as offering stronger protection against common credential attacks because authentication is cryptographically linked to the legitimate website's domain. However, their security still depends on factors such as device protection, secure credential storage, and account recovery arrangements.

## The effectiveness of multi-factor authentication in preventing account takeover.

Multi-factor authentication (MFA) is an effective security measure for reducing the likelihood of unauthorised account access. Meyer et al. (2023) investigated its effectiveness using a large dataset of Microsoft Azure Directory accounts exhibiting suspicious activity. Their findings indicated that MFA reduced the estimated risk of account compromise by 99.22% across the population. Furthermore, among accounts associated with leaked credentials, MFA reduced the estimated risk of compromise by 98.56%. These results demonstrate that requiring an additional authentication factor can provide substantial protection even when passwords have been exposed.

The study also identified differences in the effectiveness of authentication methods. Dedicated authenticator applications, such as Microsoft Authenticator, provided stronger protection that SMS-based verification, although both methods offered considerable greater security than relying on passwords without MFA. Meyer et al. (2023). This suggests that organisations should consider not only whether MFA is enabled, but also which authentication method is deployed.

Further evidence is provided by Doerfler et al. (2019), who evaluated fourteen login challenges against more than 350,000 real world account-hijacking attempts. Their findings showed that device-based challenges blocked over 94% of phishing-related attempts and 100% of automated attempts in the dataset. However, these results relate to particular device-based challenges rather than every MFA method. Overall, the studies indicate that additional authentication measures can substantially reduce account-takeover risks, although their effectiveness varies according to the authentication and the attack technique involved.

## Using 2fa over nothing at all.

(NHS England, n.d) Although SMS-based two-factor authentication (2FA) has recognised security weaknesses, it can still provide greater protection than relying on passwords alone. NHS England acknowledges that SMS authentication is vulnerable to phishing, number-porting attacks, SIM-swapping, and therefore recommends using it only when more secure alternatives and unavailable. Nevertheless, the organisation recognises that SMS-based authentication can offer an additional layer of protection in comparison to having no multi-factor authentication in place. Where SMS must be used, organisations should understand the associated security and privacy risks, implement appropriate monitoring and develop plans to transition to stronger authentication methods.

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# CYBERSECURITY AWARENESS: PUBLIC Wi-Fi SECURITY

## Introduction to Public Wi-Fi Security

Public Wi-Fi refers to wireless internet connections available in public places such as airports, hotels, cafés, libraries, and universities. These networks make internet access

convenient and affordable, but they may also introduce cybersecurity risks when connections are poorly configured, or users connect to fraudulent hotspots. Public Wi-Fi security is therefore an important part of cybersecurity awareness for students, traveler's and employees. Modern website encryption makes many online activities safer than in the past; nevertheless, users must still recognize deceptive networks, phishing pages, and device vulnerabilities (FTC, 2023).

# 1.1 Cybersecurity Threats Associated with Public Wi-Fi

## 1.1.1 Man-in-the-Middle Attacks

A man-in-the-middle (MITM) attack occurs when an attacker intercepts or manipulates communications between a device and an online service. On an insecure network, an attacker may attempt to observe traffic or redirect a user to a malicious destination. Properly implemented HTTPS encryption helps prevent attackers from reading or altering the content of website communications, although it does not make every website trustworthy (FTC, 2023).

## 1.1.2 Evil Twin Attacks

An evil twin attack involves setting up a fraudulent wireless hotspot that imitates a legitimate network. For example, an attacker might create a network called "Airport_Free_WiFi" to persuade travelersto connect. A fake network can present misleading login pages or attempt to interfere with network traffic. Peer-reviewed research by Nakhila et al. (2018) examines techniques for detecting such impersonation, illustrating that rogue access points pose a genuine technical security challenge.

## 1.1.3 Packet Sniffing and Eavesdropping

Packet sniffing is the capture and inspection of data traveling across a network. Network administrators use it legitimately for troubleshooting, but malicious actors may exploit unencrypted traffic to obtain information. The risk depends on the network configuration and the encryption used by applications. Users should therefore avoid sending sensitive information through services that do not provide secure connections (CISA, n.d.).

### 1.1.4 Malware and Phishing

Fraudulent captive portals, malicious websites and deceptive messages can trick users into revealing credentials or installing unwanted software. Attackers may exploit a user's assumption that a Wi-Fi login page is legitimate. HTTPS indicates that a connection is encrypted, not that the website itself is honest; checking addresses and treating unexpected login requests with suspicion remain essential (FTC, 2023).

## 1.2 Consequences of Insecure Public Wi-Fi Usage

Compromised accounts can result in identity theft, financial fraud, and loss of personal information. For organizations, a stolen employee password or infected device may expose customer records and internal systems, causing business disruption, reputational harm, and possible compliance problems. Risks increase when workers access sensitive resources through untrusted connections without appropriate safeguards. Organizational guidance therefore emphasizes secure remote access, staff training, and sensible access controls (FTC, 2019).

## 1.3 Preventive Measures and Best Practices

First, users should verify the network name with staff before connecting and avoid lookalike hotspots. Second, they should check that websites use HTTPS and should never ignore certificate warnings. Third, a reputable virtual private network (VPN) can encrypt traffic between a device and its VPN provider, adding protection on untrusted local networks. However, VPNs do not eliminate phishing or malware risks, and choose a trustworthy provider for matters (FTC, 2018). Fourth, multi-factor authentication (MFA) should be enabled for important accounts, because an additional verification step can limit damage if a password is stolen. Fifth, devices, browsers, and apps should be updated to address known vulnerabilities. Users should also disable automatic connection to unfamiliar hotspots and turn off unnecessary sharing features. Finally, mobile data or a personal hotspot may be preferable for sensitive tasks when the legitimacy or security of a public connection is uncertain (NCSC, 2018; FTC, 2023).

## 1.4 The Importance of Cybersecurity Awareness and Education

Technical security measures are most effective when supported by informed user behavior. People may connect to an unknown hotspot for convenience, overlook security warnings or enter passwords into a convincing fake portal. Cybersecurity education should therefore

teach network verification, phishing recognition, secure browsing, MFA and incident reporting. Universities and employers can reinforce these habits through short training sessions, practical demonstrations, and clear remote-working policies. Research on evil twin detection shows the value of technical controls, while awareness helps users make safer decisions before an attack occurs (Nakhila et al., 2018).

## 1.5 Conclusion

Public Wi-Fi provides valuable connectivity, but fraudulent access points, interception attempts, phishing and insecure applications can create cybersecurity threats. The potential consequences include compromised accounts, financial loss, and exposure of organizational information. Public Wi-Fi is not inherently unsafe: HTTPS, appropriate VPN use, MFA, software updates, and verified network selection can substantially reduce risk. Consistent cybersecurity education is essential for translating these safeguards into everyday behavior.

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# Phishing and Social Engineering

### 4.1 Understanding Phishing

## Phishing

Is an online fraud where criminals pretend to be legitimate and/or reputable companies, friends, or acquaintances by using fake emails, text messages, phone calls, or websites to trick people into sharing personal details, passwords, or bank information. They may also send links that can install malware, harmful software, on your device or steal your information, which can also sabotage systems and organisations. **(Microsoft, n.d.)**

## Spear phishing

Is a type of online swindle aimed at a particular person or organisation. Criminals use information they find online, such as someone's job, workplace, or recent activities, to make fake messages seem real. Unlike ordinary phishing emails, which often use general greetings like "Dear customer," these messages contain details about the person being targeted. The sender may pretend to be a manager or colleague to gain the victim's trust. The aim is to steal passwords or money, obtain confidential information, or persuade the person to open a dangerous link or attachment. **(Microsoft, 2026)**

## Smishing

*I*s a fraud carried out through text messages. The word comes from combining SMS and phishing. Scammers send messages that appear to come from a bank or another trusted organisation to persuade people to share personal details, provide bank information or make payments. The messages may have links to fake websites and often create a sense of urgency to encourage people to act without checking if the message is genuine. Scammers may use unknown numbers or copy an organisation's name to make the message look real. Their aim is to steal money or obtain private information. **(HSBC UK, n.d.)**

## Vishing

Is a phone fraud in which criminals pretend to be a bank or another trusted organisation to obtain people's private information. They may ask for passwords, bank details or credit card numbers over the phone or through recorded voice messages. To make their calls sound believable, they may use automated voices or details collected from the internet or previous data breaches. Some scammers also send emails asking people to ring a number, then use the call to persuade them to reveal personal details or send money. Sharing this information can result in monetary loss or identity theft, so it is important to check who is calling before giving out any details. **(Barclaycard, n.d.)**

## Business Email Compromise (BEC)

Is a type of fraud in which criminals impersonate a trusted person, such as a manager or supplier, to persuade a business or individual to transfer money or disclose confidential information. They may use a false email address that closely resembles the genuine one or gain access to an existing account by stealing its password or using malicious software. Fraudsters often make their requests appear urgent to prevent the recipient from checking whether they are genuine. These scams can cause considerable financial losses, particularly for small businesses. **(HSBC UK, n.d.)**

## Why Phishing Works

Cyber criminals often exploit human behavior by creating fear, putting people under pressure, or pretending to be someone they trust. For example, they may pretend to be a manager or bank employee and use convincing emails or phone calls to obtain confidential information or persuade someone to transfer money. These messages can be difficult to recognise because they may look genuine. Staff can also fall for such scams, even after receiving cyber security training, particularly when they are busy or under pressure at work. Spear-phishing and whaling target specific individuals and can lead to stolen information, financial losses and disruption to an organisation. **(Bhardwaj et al., 2003)**

## Common Warning Signs

Recognised indicators of a phishing message include spelling mistakes, grammatical errors and vague greetings, such as 'Dear customer'. The sender's email address may also hold unusual wording or slight misspellings of a genuine company name. Other warning signs include suspicious links, unexpected attachments and requests for passwords or bank details. Some messages create a sense of urgency by claiming that an account has a problem or threatening a penalty if the recipient does not act immediately. Scammers may also use personal information or pretend to be someone the recipient knows to make the message appear genuine. It is important to check the sender's details and verify the message before clicking on links, opening attachments or sharing personal information.

I am drawing on Microsoft guidance.

| Warning sign | Why it may be suspicious | What the user should do |
|---|---|---|
| Spelling mistakes / grammatical errors | Such errors may result from poor translation or be included deliberately bypassing email security filters. | Consider a possible sign of phishing and/or a social engineering red flag. |
| Vague greetings / urgent threats | A legit organisation is familiar with your name and scammers create urgency to pressure people | Be cautious of emails that demand immediate action. If a message demands urgent action, |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | into acting quickly without checking the message or seeking advice. | pause and check that it is genuine before responding. |
| Suspicious links / unexpected attachment | Criminals may also use emails, text messages, or phone calls to direct people to fraudulent websites and/or to install malware. | Hover over a link to view its web address and check whether it matches the one shown in the message. An unfamiliar or unrelated address may show a phishing attempt. |
| Requests for passwords / bank details | Phishing scams aim to obtain login details or trick people into sending money. | If you receive such a request, verify it by contacting the sender directly by telephone or secure messaging before acting. Always be cautious. |

*Table 3: Common phishing warning signs (Source: [citation])*

## Responding to Phishing

If someone suspects they have received or clicked on a phishing message, they should stop interacting with it and report it to their organisation's IT department if it is work-related. If they have entered their password, they should change it at once and enable multi-factor authentication. If they have shared bank details or sent money, they should contact their bank straight away. Within an organisation, the IT team should investigate the incident, check for unauthorised access and prevent further messages from the attacker where possible. They should also contact the bank promptly if a payment has been made, to see whether it can be stopped or recovered. Recording what happened and reviewing security procedures can help the organisation deal with the incident and reduce the risk of a similar attack in the future.

# Conclusion

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## Summary of Findings

- Across all five areas, criminals use deception to gain access to personal or financial information, trick people into opening harmful links, or persuade them to download unsafe files. The main risks include pecuniary loss, identity theft, stolen passwords, and malicious software infecting devices.
- Verify the sender's identity and avoid suspicious links or attachments.
- Never share passwords, PINs, or bank details with unknown callers or unverified sources.
- Contact the person or organisation through a trusted telephone number before sending money or sharing information.
- Inform the IT department of suspected workplace attacks and contact the bank immediately if money has been transferred.
- Change compromised passwords, use unique passwords for each account, and review security measures to prevent further attacks.

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